worst, it's purposefully misleading, ignorant, or full-blown Russia's Internet Research Agency propaganda. These junk arguments reveal little other than their authors' fundamental misunderstanding of finance.

If it was your ancestor who buried the cash in the mason jar, then yes, technically its buying power is 96% less today than when he stuck it in the ground in April 1917. But that's not the dollar's fault, it's your great-grandpappy's. You would be much wealthier today if your ancestors were not innumerate investing neophytes.

Currency like the USD is primarily a medium of exchange, not a store of value. That's why you don't leave it doing nothing for a century…

Holding cash for a century may be foolish, but what about holding cash for a few years or decades? Let's take a closer look.

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159 I first wrote about how ridiculous the 96% claim was that month, so let's use that date for our framework. But it works regardless of your start and end points. Try it on Nick Maggiulli's S&P 500 calculator: ofdollarsanddata.com/sp500-calculator.

160 Nick Maggiulli, "S&P 500 Historical Return Calculator [With Dividends]," Of Dollars and Data. A sum of $1,000 invested in the S&P 500 with dividends reinvested would return 10.23% annualized, and from April 1917 to July 2023 would be worth $30,761,431.21.